Supporting Small Businesses in the UK in Navigating Marketing Challenges During an Economic Downturn

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***Abstract*—The UK economy has faced major challenges since Brexit and COVID-19, including high inflation, energy and living costs, and rising rents—pressuring households and businesses alike. While some government support exists, continued tax hikes and falling consumer spending have severely impacted micro and sole traders, who often lack the financial buffer to withstand demand shocks. Their survival is increasingly uncertain.**

This study seeks to design a practical support package for UK businesses with fewer than ten employees, aiming to boost their short-term survival and long-term growth. Though relevant more broadly, the research focuses solely on this segment.

The methodology begins with a primary investigation, as directly engaging with micro and sole traders is the most effective way to understand their real needs. This initial stage involves a survey to explore financial, digital, and marketing challenges. It is followed by four phases of secondary research: a review of current support schemes, an evaluation of marketing education, an assessment of digital and AI-based tools, and an analysis of training provision tailored to small enterprises. Even if economic conditions improve, the insights gained will support future resilience. The study upholds strict ethical standards, ensuring anonymity, voluntary participation, and data protection

I. Introduction

THE UK economy is teetering on the edge of recession, placing mounting pressure on individuals and enterprises alike. In April 2025, the revised GDP showed a 0.3

Inflation has remained persistently high since January 2024, peaking in April 2025. Analysts do not expect it to fall below 3

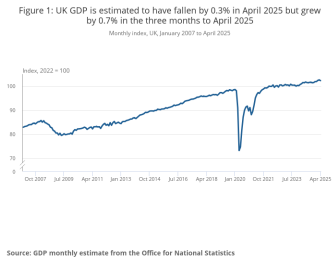

Fig. 1. [3] UK GDP Although UK GDP shows a slight rise, the outlook remains troubling.

According to recent consumer surveys, nearly half of UK shoppers intend to reduce discretionary spending [4]. This shift in household priorities is particularly concerning for micro and sole traders, who often operate with minimal financial reserves and are highly vulnerable to demand-side shocks.

In this context, the need for targeted support measures for the smallest businesses becomes not only timely, but essential.

A. INTENSIFIED MARKET COMPETITION

In periods of declining consumer demand, businesses are forced to compete more aggressively for a shrinking market share. While all enterprises face increased pressure, they do not compete on equal footing.

Capital-rich firms are better positioned to retain or grow their share through strategic marketing teams, product innovation, and expansion into new markets—advantages rooted in their financial capacity [5].

In contrast, the most vulnerable segment of the business landscape—sole traders and micro-enterprises—often lack not only the financial resources but also the digital infrastructure and marketing expertise necessary to adapt. For many, this deficit significantly undermines their chances of survival.

B. THE ECONOMIC SIGNIFICANCE OF MICRO AND SOLE TRADERS

In 2024, the UK had around 5.5 million businesses, with 99.8This segment forms a core foundation of the UK economy. A widespread collapse would disrupt business continuity and push thousands of owners and workers into the job market, worsening economic instability. The impact was already evident in 2024, when nearly 170,000 retail positions were lost [7]. Rising unemployment limits the economy's ability to absorb surplus labour, reducing spending, triggering business closures, and shrinking production capacity—deepening recession and hindering recovery. Italy exemplifies how weak crisis responses can intensify downturns, while Canada showed how timely, targeted support can stabilise conditions. Given the UK's heavy reliance on micro and sole traders, safeguarding this group is vital to achieving sustainable recovery.

C. RESEARCH DESIGN

This study will directly consult micro and sole traders to determine which forms of support they view as essential for navigating today's economic challenges. While aiming for 500 responses may seem ambitious, it remains realistic, as the survey aligns with the participants' own interests—enhancing their long-term viability and competitiveness. The research seeks to design a tailored package for UK enterprises with fewer than ten employees, combining financial aid with access to digital tools and training in independent marketing. Its structure will be informed by both primary insights and secondary findings. Ultimately, the goal is to develop a practical

resilience toolkit to support microbusinesses through economic uncertainty.

II. BACKGROUND

During downturns, medium and large firms benefit from financial strength, which enables resilience and long-term planning despite slower decision-making [8]. By contrast, micro and sole traders (0–9 employees) typically operate with low income and limited capital, without crisis or marketing teams. Being owner-led, outcomes often depend on personal judgement, personality, and confidence. As Miller notes, strategic direction usually mirrors the owner's traits [9]. Their vulnerability increases due to constrained management capacity and resources. Still, some micro-enterprises adapt during recessions—by revising contracts, modifying products, cutting costs, or increasing promotion [10]. Access to finance is crucial for survival and growth [8]. Roper and Hart highlight a positive cycle between higher sales and job creation, regardless of macroeconomic conditions. Thus, policy tools like tax relief, grants, credit access, and marketing support are essential—not only for business continuity but also to stimulate demand. The following section compares Italy's and Canada's 2008–2009 crisis responses, showing how strategic choices shape recovery paths.

A. ITALY'S ECONOMIC TRANSFORMATION AND EARLY WARNING SIGNS

Following World War II, Italy experienced strong economic growth, which persisted until the 1970s. While GDP continued to rise, total factor productivity (TFP) stagnated and then declined—a shift that remained largely invisible in standard macroeconomic indicators [11].

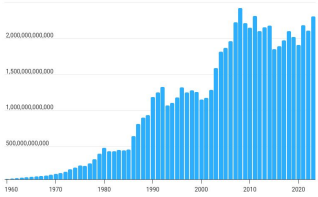

Fig. 2. [12] GDP ITALY: Despite the GDP curve suggesting only a brief stagnation in the 1980s followed by renewed growth, deeper analysis reveals a significant decline in productivity between 1988 and 2019 [13].

The 2008–2009 global financial crisis severely affected Italy's economy, as Di Quirico outlines [14]. Restricted lending, weak demand, and high energy costs strained SMEs. Many firms downsized, unemployment rose, output fell, and thousands ceased trading. Meanwhile, public finances worsened due to falling tax income and rising welfare costs. Policy responses focused mainly on spending cuts and support for industry and agriculture, neglecting other sectors. Although SMEs remained central, many lacked the innovation and technology needed to regain competitiveness. According to the Resolution Foundation [13], Italy's stagnation reflects deep-rooted structural flaws: weak stimulus, many low-productivity legacy firms, limited competition, and chronic underinvestment in skills. The UK could face similar risks if such issues remain unaddressed—making Italy a cautionary case.

B. CANADA'S RECESSION STRATEGY: A MODEL OF RAPID AND INCLUSIVE POLICY ACTION

During the 2008–2009 global recession, Canada's federal government responded with exceptional speed and coordination. Within six weeks, it launched a far-reaching Economic Action Plan, shaped through consultations with provincial leaders, academics, private sector representatives, and thousands of citizens via online platforms [16].

A key element expanded small business finance: loan ceilings rose to CAD 500,000, backed by an 85Wider stabilisation efforts included a CAD 200 billion credit facility for businesses and households, a CAD 8.3 billion retraining programme, and extended tax relief to bolster household consumption. CAD 7.8 billion supported affordable housing and energy-efficient refurbishments. Infrastructure investment was another pillar, with nearly CAD 12 billion allocated to transport, broadband, and healthcare systems. Targeted relief also addressed the hardest-hit regions and industries, combining short-term aid with long-term resilience.

By mid-2010, Canada's economy had returned to growth, ahead of many advanced economies still facing recessionary pressures [18]. The Canadian case highlights how timely, inclusive, and multi-dimensional policy—along with measures that supported small businesses—can restore economic stability and rebuild public trust.

Fig. 3. [18] Canada's GDP shows declines in 2009 and 2020, followed by swift recovery.

C. AVAILABLE RESOURCES AND IDENTIFIED GAPS

In the UK, a wide array of initiatives exists to support micro and sole traders, including start-up financing, innovation guidance, digital skills development, export assistance, and regional advisory services. These are provided by organisations such as GOV.UK [19], Barclays Eagle Labs [20], the Open University [21], and the Small Business Charter [22].

However, most programmes concentrate primarily on financial, managerial, or technological domains. Tailored marketing assistance remains limited, and where present, it is often too broad or overly technical—overlooking the emotional and creative dimensions of outreach. Consequently, such offerings are frequently inadequate for equipping small enterprises with the applied communication skills necessary for market success.

This shortfall highlights the urgent need for accessible, practice-based learning in marketing design and delivery—particularly during economic downturns, when visibility and customer connection are essential to survival.

D. THE ROLE OF DIGITAL MARKETING

Recent studies highlight the growing importance of digital engagement for micro and sole traders. Research from Jordan shows that building an online presence—via social media, digital advertising, and SEO—can substantially expand market reach and boost revenue [23]. These methods increasingly depend on advanced technologies such as AI and cloud-based platforms, enhancing both efficiency and competitiveness.

However, success depends not only on tool availability but also on the ability to influence consumer behaviour and convert investment into growth. Many micro firms face barriers, including limited budgets and weak digital literacy, which hinder effective use.

Sharabati et al. emphasise the value of accessible, hands-on training to help even the smallest businesses adopt digital tools strategically. Though rooted in the Jordanian context, similar issues persist in the UK, where support programmes and infrastructure are available, but often lack the guidance needed for meaningful impact.

This study also examines the extent to which UK micro and sole traders have access to digital tools, practical skills, and marketing awareness. The findings will contribute to shaping a cohesive development model—integrating funding, technology, training, and targeted promotion.

E. SUMMARY

Micro and sole traders are among the most vulnerable during recessions. In the UK, their prevalence means widespread failures could destabilise the economy. While recovery depends on multiple factors, supporting this segment is vital to sustaining competitiveness and resilience. Italy's example highlights the importance of keeping small enterprises active.

Although the UK offers various support schemes, none directly address marketing competence. Transitioning to digital platforms and gaining promotional skills is essential. Outsourcing advertising has limited value if leaders lack insight into their firm's unique strengths. For micro firms, effective marketing often relies on the owner's understanding of its emotional appeal.

Despite extensive searches, no studies were found assessing whether these leaders possess sufficient marketing knowledge, nor any accessible training programmes addressing this gap.

Providing tools and funding without the skills to apply them limits impact. This study further highlights this overlooked issue and recommends targeted marketing education as an essential addition to current support initiatives.

III. PROBLEM STATEMENT

The UK's recent economic downturn has intensified competition across all sectors, disproportionately affecting micro and sole traders due to their limited financial capital. While large enterprises can absorb market shocks, smaller firms could offset their disadvantage by enhancing digital adoption and marketing capabilities. However, no publicly available programmes currently address the development of practical marketing knowledge for this group.

Given that micro and sole traders represent over 96

A. HYPOTHESES

H1: Micro and sole traders in the UK lack sufficient financial resources to withstand an economic crisis.

H2: These businesses do not have adequate access to digital tools or the knowledge to use them effectively.

H3: Their marketing knowledge and resources are insufficient to manage promotional activities independently and effectively, reducing their chances of survival and growth during economic downturns.

IV. RESEARCH METHODOLOGY

This study applies both primary and secondary research methods.

A. Step 1: Primary Research

The primary phase involves a structured Google Forms questionnaire targeting micro and sole traders in the UK, with a target of 500 responses to ensure relevance.

The survey will be distributed via Facebook groups (e.g. UK Sole Traders, Women in Business UK), and, if needed, extended to LinkedIn and networks such as the FSB and BCC. It includes mainly closed questions, with an optional open field for qualitative input.

Collected data will be exported to Excel and analysed in Python using pandas for data processing, matplotlib and seaborn for visualisation, and wordcloud for text insights. Business names are requested only for verification; responses are anonymised and handled confidentially for research purposes.

B. Step 2: Mapping Existing Support

This phase entails a structured review of UK-wide and regional schemes for micro and sole traders, including financial aid, training, and advisory services. Information will be gathered via keyword searches on platforms such as GOV.UK and DBT, local authority websites, and regional growth hubs. Relevant programme documents, guidelines, and policy papers will be analysed. Further input will be sought from Local Enterprise Partnerships (LEPs), the FSB, Small Business Charter, and advocacy groups to uncover any unlisted initiatives. Schemes will be categorised in Excel by type, region, eligibility, and marketing relevance.

C. Step 3: Evaluating Marketing Education

This phase reviews marketing and entrepreneurship training programmes available in the UK, with a focus on whether they effectively convey the emotional dimensions of marketing—such as authentic messaging, consumer trust, and self-representation—considered critical for micro and sole traders. Courses will be evaluated based on: • accessibility (free or paid), • content (theoretical vs practical), • intended audience (general or small business-specific), • and the degree to which emotional marketing is integrated. Programmes will be systematically compared in Excel using these criteria to assess whether current provision is sufficient, or if there is a need for a more practice-oriented alternative.

D. Step 4: Analysing Digital and Marketing Tools

This stage identifies the most effective digital and AI-based resources available to micro and sole traders. The aim is to assess their impact on business operations, customer acquisition, and promotional activities.

Solutions will be ranked based on expert reviews, professional publications, platform evaluations, and user feedback, with emphasis on ease of use, affordability, and suitability for small enterprises. Data will be organised in Excel and compared across key dimensions, including functionality, pricing, usability, and support.

E. Step 5: Assessing Government-Backed Digital Training

This phase evaluates whether publicly funded digital courses address the practical needs of micro and sole traders. Content, methodology, and intended audience will be reviewed and benchmarked against proven, independent options. The analysis will emphasise practical relevance and applicability. Results will be summarised in Excel to support recommendations on which initiatives could be incorporated into the proposed educational offering.

F. Limitations

While the study aims for thoroughness, some existing support schemes may remain unidentified. The expected sample size of approximately 500 businesses, though not exhaustive, is considered broadly representative. Recommendations will be developed with careful consideration of practical constraints and the scope of available resources.

G. Ethical Considerations

This study aims to evaluate public schemes and propose a practical model for supporting micro and sole traders, raising ethical concerns that will be addressed throughout the process. All survey materials will use neutral language to avoid misrepresenting government policy or raising unrealistic expectations. Participants will be clearly informed that no direct funding is offered and that the research is exploratory. Data will be collected via an online, voluntary survey distributed through business communities. Respondents can withdraw at any time. All responses will be anonymised; any optional business details will be treated confidentially and stored securely. Ethical approval will be sought from the university's ethics committee if required. Both primary and secondary sources will be evaluated for credibility to ensure balanced and accurate interpretation.

V. PRELIMINARY RESULTS

1) Existing Support Schemes: UK micro and sole traders can access a range of government initiatives offering loans, innovation support, investor links, and digital upskilling [19]. Programmes such as Be the Business, Local Growth Hubs, and Barclays provide workshops, mentoring, and financial literacy sessions [20], while the Open University offers free online courses in leadership, budgeting, and entrepreneurship [21]. Though some schemes address marketing, they often focus on corporate branding or cite large firms like Coca-Cola and BMW—poorly suited to small enterprises. The Small Business Charter, for instance, prioritises innovation and crisis response over practical promotional skills [22]. Moreover, many use formal language and complex concepts—especially on digital tools and consumer behaviour—neglecting emotional and adaptive skills vital for building trust and visibility. Without simplified, practical training, entrepreneurs may fail to benefit fully from existing resources. These findings indicate a need for marketing education tailored to micro-business realities.

VI. EXPECTED OUTCOMES / CONTRIBUTION

The research is expected to reveal that many UK micro and sole traders: – lack sufficient capital to withstand demand shocks – do not use appropriate digital tools – have limited knowledge of digital technologies – make minimal use of marketing software – feel unequipped to manage promotion due to inadequate marketing expertise These capability gaps signal the need for accessible, small business–oriented training and guidance. The study proposes an integrated package of funding, digital tools, hands-on training, and targeted marketing education. This framework aims not only to identify barriers but also to offer a practical, scalable model to strengthen resilience and promote sustainable growth across the micro-business sector. The approach may inform future support strategies.

VII. CONCLUSION

In summary, the study aims to bridge existing capability gaps and offer a concrete, actionable contribution to policy and practice during economic downturns.

Appendix A
Timeline of the Research

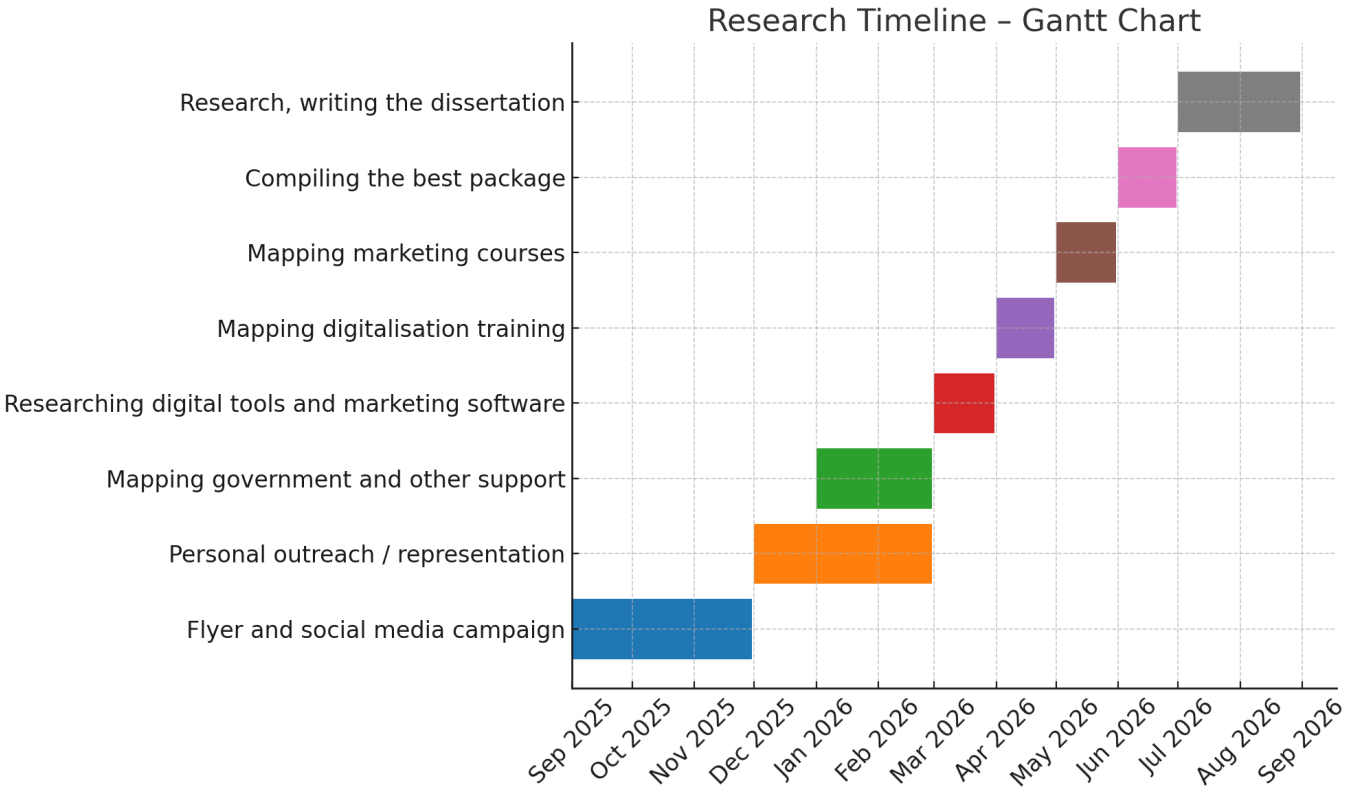

Fig. 4. Timeline of key events in the research

Appendix B
Survey Questionnaire

RESEARCH QUESTIONNAIRE

You are invited to take part in a university research study investigating the most effective forms of support for small businesses during times of economic recession or downturn.

The study aims to bridge existing capability gaps and offer a concrete, actionable contribution to both policy and practice.
This survey forms part of a postgraduate research project at a UK university.

Participation is entirely voluntary, and you may skip any question or withdraw at any time.

We kindly request your business name to help ensure the contextual relevance of responses. While this means the survey is not fully anonymous, all answers will be treated with strict confidentiality and used solely for academic purposes.

Thank you for your time and valuable contribution.

BUSINESS-RELATED INFORMATION

1.Business name: _____

2. Business location (please tick one):

☐ England

☐ Wales

☐ Scotland

☐ Northern Ireland

☐ Europe

3. Your role in the business (please tick one):

☐ Owner

☐ Manager

☐ Owner and Manager

☐ Other: _____

4. Number of employees (please tick one):

☐ 0–1

☐ 2–3

☐ 4–6

☐ 7–9

☐ 10–49

☐ 50–249

☐ 250+

5. Annual business turnover (please tick one):

☐ Up to £632,000

☐ £632,001 – £10.2 million

☐ £10.2 – £36 million

☐ Above £36 million

6. Business sector (Please tick all that apply):

☐ Agriculture

☐ Manufacturing

☐ Construction

☐ Wholesale & Retail

☐ Hospitality

☐ Transport & Storage

☐ Information & Communication

☐ Financial & Insurance

☐ Real Estate

☐ Professional Services

☐ Health & Social Care

☐ Education

☐ Arts & Entertainment

☐ Administrative Services (e.g. cleaning, payroll, office services)

☐ Other

7. Does your business export products or services? (please tick one)

☐ Yes

☐ No

☐ Planning to in the future

MARKET RESILIENCE

8. How do you perceive the current situation in the UK? (please tick one)

☐ Easier than three years ago

☐ About the same as three years ago

☐ More difficult than three years ago, but stable

☐ More difficult than three years ago and worsening

☐ More difficult than three years ago and worsening

9. Have you experienced a decline in turnover over the past 3 years? (please tick one)

☐ Yes

☐ No

10. Have you experienced a decline in turnover over the past 1 year? (please tick one)

☐ Yes

☐ No

11. If your business experienced a sustained 20% decline in turnover, what actions would you be able to take? (please tick one)

☐ None

☐ Staff reduction

☐ Negotiating lower rental costs

☐ Reducing internal marketing expenses

☐ Reducing advertising budget

☐ Renegotiating supplier terms

☐ Producing goods at lower cost

☐ Changing inventory approach

☐ Increasing prices

☐ Reducing working hours

☐ Increasing working hours

☐ Other: _____

12. If your business experienced a sustained 20% decline in turnover, how long would it be able to operate under those conditions? (please tick one)

☐ 1–6 months

☐ 6–12 months

☐ 2–3 years

☐ Indefinitely

13. If your business experienced a sustained 40% decline in turnover, what actions would you be able to take? (please tick one)

☐ None

☐ Staff reduction

☐ Negotiating lower rental costs

☐ Reducing internal marketing expenses

☐ Reducing advertising budget

☐ Renegotiating supplier terms

☐ Producing goods at lower cost

☐ Changing inventory approach

☐ Increasing prices

☐ Reducing working hours

☐ Increasing working hours

☐ Other: _____

14. If your business experienced a sustained 40% decline in turnover, how long would it be able to operate under those conditions? (please tick one)

☐ 1–6 months

☐ 6–12 months

☐ 2–3 years

☐ Indefinitely

15. Would you consider using government support to help your business stay operational? (Please tick one)

☐ Yes

☐ No

☐ I don't know

16. How familiar are you with available government support schemes? (Please tick one)

☐ Not at all

☐ Slightly

☐ I am aware and monitor them

17. Would you consider taking out a loan to maintain business operations? (Please tick one)

☐ Yes

☐ Definitely not

☐ I don't know / I haven't thought about it

DIGITALISATION, MARKETING AND ADVERTISING

Research suggests that businesses that are more digitally advanced, equipped with modern marketing tools, and capable of running effective advertising campaigns tend to be more resilient in the face of recessions or economic shocks.

18. Which of the following tools and platforms does your business currently use? (Please tick all that apply.)

☐ **Digital payment systems**
(e.g. SumUp, Zettle, PayPal, Stripe, Square, Revolut Business)
☐ **Website and e-commerce platforms**
(e.g. Shopify UK, Wix UK, WordPress + WooCommerce, Squarespace UK)
☐ **Online invoicing and accounting software**
(e.g. QuickBooks UK, Xero, FreeAgent, Sage Business Cloud Accounting)
☐ **Cloud storage and document management**
(e.g. Google Drive, Microsoft OneDrive, Dropbox Business)
☐ **CRM – Customer Relationship Management**
(e.g. HubSpot, Zoho CRM, Pipedrive, Capsule CRM – UK-based)
☐ **Online communication tools**
(e.g. Zoom, Microsoft Teams, WhatsApp Business, Slack)
☐ **Social media platforms**
(e.g. Facebook, Instagram, TikTok, LinkedIn, X/Twitter – UK versions)
☐ **Social media management tools**
(e.g. Meta Business Suite, Buffer, Hootsuite, Later)
☐ **Content creation tools (graphics, video)**
(e.g. Canva, Adobe Express, VistaCreate, CapCut, Lumen5)
☐ **AI-based ad creation tools**
(e.g. AdCreative.ai, Designs.ai, InVideo, Pictory, Animoto)
☐ **Advertising campaign management platforms**
(e.g. Google Ads, Meta Ads Manager, AdEspresso, Smartly.io)
☐ **Email marketing software**
(e.g. Mailchimp, Brevo, Moosend, GetResponse, MailerLite)
☐ **Marketing automation tools**
(e.g. ActiveCampaign, Mailchimp Automation, HubSpot Workflows, Zoho Campaigns)
☐ **Web analytics and behavioural tracking**
(e.g. Google Analytics, Looker Studio, Hotjar, Meta Insights)
☐ **SEO and keyword research tools**
(e.g. SEMrush, Ubersuggest, Ahrefs, Moz – UK keyword focus)

☐ **Form builders and lead capture tools**
(e.g. Unbounce, ConvertKit, Jotform, Typeform)
☐ **Customer review and rating collection platforms**
(e.g. Trustpilot, Feefo, Google Reviews)
☐ **Online booking and calendar management tools**
(e.g. Calendly, SimplyBook.me, Fresha)
☐ **Marketing dashboards and reporting tools**
(e.g. Looker Studio, Databox, Klipfolio)
☐ **UK-specific digital support platforms**
(e.g. GOV.UK – Digital Skills Hub, Barclays Digital Wings, NatWest Business Builder)
☐ **Other:** _____

19. Would you be able to use additional digital tools beyond those you currently use? (Please tick one)

☐ Yes, if there was a clear need for it
☐ No, I do not know how to use them
☐ If I received training on how to use them
☐ If needed, I'm confident I could learn on my own
☐ I do not wish to use any additional tools and would prefer to avoid them

20. Please indicate which internal marketing elements your business uses:
(Tick all that apply)

☐ Internal communication
(e.g., daily verbal check-ins, WhatsApp groups, notice boards, shared calendars)

☐ Employee training
(e.g., product knowledge, customer service, complaint handling, onboarding new staff)

☐ Leading by example
(e.g., the owner's or manager's attitude and behaviour sets the tone)

☐ Recognition and incentives
(e.g., praise, bonuses, gifts, time off, customer feedback-based rewards)

☐ Organisational culture building
(e.g., creating a positive atmosphere, shared values, internal norms, friendly environment)

☐ Employee involvement in decision-making
(e.g., idea generation, suggestion collection, choosing shared actions or decorations)

☐ Uniform / visual identity
(e.g., branded clothing, coordinated colours, tidy appearance)

☐ Team cohesion
(e.g., shared lunches, team-building days, birthday celebrations, internal chat groups)

☐ Internal campaigns and events
(e.g., "best customer service" awards, competitions, decoration challenges)

☐ Promoting customer-oriented thinking
(e.g., understanding the customer's perspective, kindness, politeness, thinking "why do they return?")

☐ Other: _____

21. What methods does your business use to communicate with customers?
(Tick all that apply)

☐ Requesting feedback
(e.g., asking the customer after purchase whether they were satisfied with the product/service)

☐ Email communication
(e.g., order confirmation, informational messages, thank-you notes, newsletters)

☐ Complaint handling
(e.g., responding to customer issues politely, promptly, and with a solution-focused approach)

☐ Social media responses
(e.g., monitoring and responding positively to messages, comments, and reviews)

☐ Phone contact
(e.g., short and polite calls to confirm appointments or respond to enquiries)

☐ In-store communication
(e.g., helpfulness, advice, and recommendations delivered calmly and attentively)

☐ Thank-you message or gift
(e.g., small surprise after purchase, handwritten card, or memorable thank-you email)

☐ Sending surveys
(e.g., online or paper surveys requesting feedback on the service)

☐ Asking for referrals
(e.g., encouraging satisfied customers to share their experiences or leave reviews)

☐ Post-purchase follow-up
(e.g., "Thank you for visiting us! How did you like the product?", or product recommendations)

☐ Other: _____

22. How well do you know your competitors?
(Please tick one)

☐ I know them very well and regularly conduct market research
☐ I have a general understanding of their activities
☐ I do not monitor them at all

23. Through which channels does your business advertise?
(Please tick all that apply)

☐ Social media
(Facebook posts and ads, Instagram photos, Reels, TikTok videos, YouTube Shorts)
☐ Own website
(homepage promotions, banners, pop-up windows, blog posts, SEO content)
☐ Google Ads
(search ads, display banners on other websites, YouTube video ads)
☐ Offline printed materials
(flyers, posters, brochures, newspaper ads, direct mail)
☐ Physical shop or business premises
(window display, indoor posters, counter displays, TV or screen advertisements)
☐ Local events and fairs
(booth, banners, branded giveaways, outdoor promotions, product tasting)
☐ Email marketing
(newsletters, promotional emails, automated campaigns via Mailchimp or other tools)
☐ Partnership collaborations
(joint campaigns, coupon exchange, guest content on each other's platforms)
☐ Influencer marketing
(posts by local influencers, product reviews, testimonial videos, social media endorsements)
☐ Online marketplace advertising
(promotions on Etsy, eBay, Amazon, featured product placements)
☐ Outdoor advertising
(bus stop posters, citylight displays, vehicle ads – where available)
☐ Branded merchandise
(logo-branded pens, bags, mugs – items customers take home, enhancing visibility)
☐ Other: _____

24. Who is responsible for creating your company's advertisements?
(Please tick one)

☐ We do not advertise
☐ Created in-house
☐ Outsourced to an external agency or professional
☐ Other: _____

25. How strategically does your business approach advertising?
(Please tick all that apply)

☐ We do not advertise
☐ We advertise to a clearly defined target audience
☐ We advertise through channels that effectively reach our target audience
☐ We design our advertisements using emotional elements that appeal to and motivate our target audience
☐ We monitor competitors' advertising practices and follow their approach
☐ We copy advertisements from other businesses
☐ We have no advertising or marketing knowledge; we just try to create advertisements.

26. How effective do you consider your advertising efforts to be? ***(Please tick one)***
☐ We do not advertise
☐ Advertising leads to a noticeable increase in sales
☐ Advertising leads to a minimal increase in sales
☐ Advertising has no observable effect
☐ Advertising is an unnecessary extra expense and does not pay off

27. How often do you measure the effectiveness of your advertising? ***(Please tick one)***
☐ After every campaign
☐ Once a year
☐ Based only on intuition
☐ We do not measure it

28. How effective are your company's advertisements? ***(Please tick one)***
☐ We do not advertise
☐ Very effective
☐ Minimally effective
☐ No observable impact
☐ Advertising is just an unnecessary extra expense that does not pay off

DIRECTION OF SUPPORT

29. What additional knowledge would help your business increase its revenue?
(Please tick all that apply)

☐ Internal marketing training
☐ Industry-specific training
☐ Training on the use of digital tools
☐ Learning how to create our own effective advertisements

30. In the event of an economic crisis, if you could assemble a 5-item support package to help your business, which of the following would you include?
(Please select up to 5)

☐ Financial support from the government or local authority

(one-off grant for small businesses)

☐ Tax relief, deferral or reduction

(e.g. instalment plans, temporary tax breaks during crisis periods)

☐ Flexible rental agreement or subsidised business premises

(reduced rent, access to shared retail space, pop-up stand)

☐ Discounted marketing software subscription

(e.g. Canva Pro, Hootsuite, Mailchimp – for professional campaigns)

☐ Free marketing training

(online course on low-cost, effective advertising)

☐ Access to online marketplaces or platforms

(e.g. Amazon, Etsy, eBay – free product listing or delivery partner schemes)

☐ Stock or warehousing support

(e.g. subsidised logistics, temporary storage, covered delivery costs)

☐ Support with energy and operational costs

(heating, electricity, other operational expenses)

☐ Simple, fast-access low-interest loan

(small business loan with low paperwork, low interest and fast approval)

☐ Mentoring or business consulting

(expert guidance on survival and growth strategies)

☐ Digital advertising credit

(e.g. Google Ads or Facebook ad budget provided)

☐ Free customer service or CRM software

(e.g. HubSpot, Brevo – for managing client relations and email automation)

☐ Networking or business cluster platform

(collaboration with other businesses, joint marketing or cost-sharing)

☐ Participation in local community marketing campaigns

(e.g. "Support Local" initiatives led by councils or nonprofits)

☐ Digital tool advisory service

(how to use social media, e-commerce, online payments effectively)

Thank you very much for completing this questionnaire.
I truly appreciate your time and effort.
Wishing you all the best in your business journey!

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